Worksheet 4.8

Science Quest 7: pages 163–165

Spot the pest

Answers

European settlers changed much of the Australian wilderness into farmland. They introduced new animals into Australia for food, transport and companionship. Some of these tame (or domestic) animals escaped and became wild. As feral animals, they preyed on native species and destroyed habitats. Some, such as rabbits and foxes, were brought here to be hunted as sport. Others, such as rats, made their own way via ships. Some animals have been introduced as a biological control for other pests.

Instructions

1. On the following page are pictures of introduced animals. Match each picture with where you think it should go on the chart. Write the name of the animal in the correct box.

I sneaked into Australia via the ropes and riggings of ships. Mouse	I was brought to Australia as a pet. I enjoy eating birds and rodents. Cat	I was introduced to provide food (milk and meat). Cow	I was brought to Australia as transport and to help with farming. Horse
I was introduced to provide food (meat and eggs). Chicken	I was introduced to provide food, but now enjoy wallowing in mud and digging up the land. Pig	I was brought to Australia thousands of years ago. Dingo	I was brought to Australia as transport for the early explorers. Camel
I was brought to Australia as a pet, and am usually very faithful. Dog	I sneaked into Australia on the hull of a ship. Northern Pacific sea star	I was introduced into Australia by scientists to control another pest. Cane toad	I was introduced into Australia for sport. I enjoy eating bilbies. Fox

2. Circle each animal you think has become a pest in Australia. Give reasons for your choices.

Answers will vary. Examples are given.

Dingo: predator of native wildlife

Cat: pest when feral because it kills native wildlife

Mouse: can cause social, economic and environmental problems when in plague proportions

Dog: wild dogs prey on livestock such as sheep, cattle and goats. Predator of native wildlife.

Pig: feral pigs cause agricultural damage through predation of newborn lambs, reduction in crop yields, damage to fences/water sources and competition with stock for feed by consuming or damaging pasture. They disrupt and damage native ecosystems because they dig up land.

Horse: wild horses can damage native vegetation and impact on pasture and grazing land.

Camel: feral camels in Central Australia damage native vegetation and affect pasture and grazing land.

Northern Pacific sea star: damages marine ecosystem

Cane toad: interferes with reproduction of native frogs; eats other native wildlife

3. Research one of these pests. Prepare a one-page report outlining why it was introduced to Australia, how it became a pest and what is being done to control it.

Answers will vary.

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